

TEETH

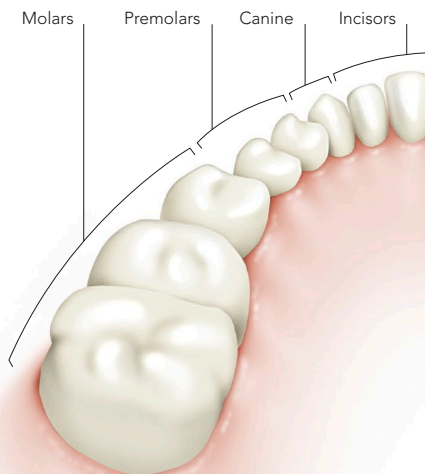
There are four types of tooth, each of which has a different role. The incisors, at the front, are chisel-shaped, with sharp edges for cutting food. The pointed canines, known as “eye teeth”, are designed for tearing food. The premolars, with their two ridges, and the flatter molars, which are the largest and strongest teeth, crush and grind food. The crown is the part of the tooth above the gum, while the root is embedded in the jawbone; and where these two meet, at the gum or gingival surface, is the neck of the tooth. The outer layer of the crown is made of a bone-like enamel, which is the hardest substance in the body. Beneath it is a layer of softer but still strong tissue called dentine, which is

shock-absorbing. At the centre of the tooth, the soft dental pulp contains blood vessels and nerves. Below the gum, bone-like cementum and periodontal ligament tissues secure the tooth in the jawbone.



ENAMEL SURFACE

This microscope image of enamel shows U-shaped enamel prisms packed with the crystalline mineral substance hydroxyapatite.



ADULT DENTITION

An adult typically has, in each side of each jaw, two incisors, one canine, two premolars, and three molars. This makes a total of 32 teeth. However, in some individuals certain teeth never grow or erupt out of the gum. This applies particularly to the four rearmost molars, known as “wisdom teeth”.

